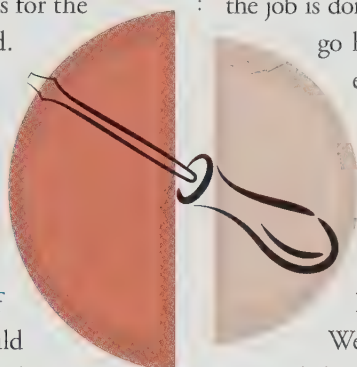


ing a nail in with the back of your shoe ain't gonna cut it. Neither is that nifty saw you got in the \$1 store with fewer teeth than your granny. Do yourself a favor: If you're going to DIY, buy quality tools like the pros, and research your job fully so you have all the right tools for the particular job at hand.

2. The Superman (or Wonder Woman) syndrome

You ever meet one of those people who could do everything better than you? They're the same people who think they can build an entire house in one weekend with no help from anyone else. This is known as working beyond your scope. If you can't do plumbing, don't do plumbing. If you're rotten with heights, avoid the roof. Don't think that you can stand on tiptoes on the top rung of a rickety old ladder and think you'll always be safe. One day you'll be telling your DIY story in the ER. According to the U.S. Consumer Product Safety Commission, ladder mishaps land over 164,000 people in the emergency room each year. So, if electrical work happens to be your Kryptonite, steer clear.



3. Permits? What permits?

Permits aren't there to just be a pain in your butt. They have a real purpose, and it's in your best interest. Those folks in the permit office are there to make sure the job is done right and that you don't go hurting yourself or anyone else. They also ensure that when you do an improvement, your insurance carrier has the necessary paperwork to keep you covered. Don't quite know if you need one?

Well, unless you're just giving a lick of paint or new layer of paper to the guest room, chances are you'll need one. If in any doubt, call your local building department.

4. Saving a few too many bucks on materials

I love a bargain, too. But make sure you know where to draw the line. Quarter-inch drywall may save you a fortune, but it's about as effective as a pair of curtains for soundproofing. You'll need 3/4-inch for a good sound barrier. And flooring is the same story; 3/4 plywood is your best friend when it comes to keeping the noise down and giving you a strong